Orange in cultures and traditions

Orange does not have the same **meaning** everywhere. In one country it is the colour of football and celebration, in another of civic protest or the sacred. Let us look at a few places and read them well.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how orange is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image.

Orange in different cultures

The Netherlands

The colour of national pride, celebration and football. Fans dress in orange, the national team is “Oranje”. At the celebrations of the King's birthday (Koningsdag, 27 April) the whole country wraps itself in orange.

From the House of Orange. The Principality of Orange in southern France (from 1163) was inherited in 1544 by William the Silent of Nassau, later leader of the revolt against Spain. According to the usual accounts the family adopted the colour in the 1570s and it became a symbol of resistance and of the state. The name of the principality was originally unrelated to the fruit.

A colour can become the common language of a whole country when there is a story and a ritual behind it.

India and Buddhist countries

In Hinduism deep saffron (in Sanskrit often called bhagwa) is regarded as one of the most sacred colours and is worn by holy men, the sadhus. Theravada Buddhist monks usually wear a saffron or ochre robe. The saffron stripe on the Indian flag is often interpreted as courage and renunciation.

Buddhist texts specify what colour a monk's robe should be, and the exact shade differs by school and country. Saffron denotes the whole range from yellow-orange to deep orange-red. Tibetan monks, by contrast, wear mainly maroon and yellow.

Orange can be the colour of **renunciation and simplicity**, because it is worn by those who gave up possessions. For them it is the opposite of showing off.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Ukraine

In 2004 orange became the colour of civic protest and non-violent change. People wore orange scarves, ribbons and flags.

Orange was the colour of Viktor Yushchenko's campaign. The opposing side chose blue, and so the colours became a political label. After the annulment of the election and a repeat vote in December 2004 Yushchenko became president.

A colour can be a tool of **shared identity**. For some it is still a story of hope, for others a political slogan. As everywhere, it depends on who is interpreting it.

Mexico

Traditionally, altars are decorated with marigolds (cempasúchil) at the celebrations of the Day of the Dead. According to tradition the orange and yellow petals show the souls the way home and their scent attracts them.

From indigenous traditions and their connection with Christian feasts. Descriptions differ by region.

Orange can be the colour of **remembering, not of sadness**. It is a warm path between life and memory.

The same colour, opposing stories

In the Netherlands it unites football crowds, in Northern Ireland it recalls division, in India it means renunciation, in Thailand Thursday and in Ukraine hope. **A colour does not have one meaning. It has as many meanings as stories people have learned to attach to it.** If you create for an international audience, or when a colour unexpectedly “does not fit” in a foreign country, it is often not a mistake, just a different story.

Orange in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at orange **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and a source of inspiration, not a healing guide.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Traditional Chinese medicine

In Chinese tradition there are five elements. Wood, fire, earth, metal and water. Orange is not among the classical colours of the five elements. **We find it between fire (red) and earth (yellow).** In the so-called generating cycle fire gives birth to earth. Fire turns to ash and from the ash soil is formed.

Earth is the element of the centre, of late summer, of sweet taste, of the spleen and stomach, that is, of digestion. The emotion of earth in the tradition is worry and going round in circles with thoughts. Its strength is that it nourishes.

Orange can be read as a bridge. **The energy of fire that turns into the nourishment of earth.** Joy that becomes what nourishes you. It is not a classical assignment, it is a reading in the spirit of the tradition.

What you can take from it. Ask whether your energy turns into something that nourishes you. If not, the body may feel unsettled, thoughtful, without appetite and with a feeling that you are running all the time. What helps is regular warm food, a calm meal in company and enough rest.

And again you can ask

"What really gives me energy?"

It is not enough only to burn. You also need to be fed

Perhaps you can create a pleasant atmosphere wherever you go. You get the conversation flowing, encourage the others, bring something good. Only then you come home and find that you have again given all your warmth out. In this image two needs meet. **I want to be among people, and I need something pleasant to remain for me too.**

Orange can accompany a moment that not only keeps you busy but also nourishes you. For example a shared meal at which you are not a host in non-stop service. You sit, you eat and the others have brought something too. An apricot tablecloth or a terracotta bowl can support the impression of a warm shared place. What matters, though, is that you really sit at that table too.

When you have little energy

If days blend together, try something pleasant that speaks to the senses. A flower, the scent of a cut orange, your favourite music or a short painting session with no result plan. The benefit can be a moment when you again perceive something with appetite instead of just fulfilling another task. If orange does not speak to you, there is no need to surround yourself with it. What should interest us is the return to experience.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

When, on the contrary, there is too much of everything

Lots of people, noise, duties, colours and social performance. Then another radiant orange can feel like an invitation to a party you have long wanted to leave. Try to put a big rich area out of view. Keep, say, just a muted ceramic or a natural fabric. In personal experience you find out how much liveliness delights you and from what amount it begins to keep you busy.

Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. It describes a person by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance what there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. Orange is warm, warming and stimulating.

How it relates to the colour orange. According to some sources orange in Ayurveda is read as the colour of warmth and zest for life, linked with the "fire of digestion". **That is why it suits where there is too much cold and heaviness.**

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. A rich orange can add fire. The tradition advises cooling and soft colours and orange only in gentle shades.

- **Orange in moderation**
  Peach or light apricot, only as an accent.
- **Add some cool**
  Green, blue and white as a counterbalance.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but restless, and is often cold. Warm colours generally suit her, but ones that are too garish may increase restlessness. **It is best to notice how you really feel in orange.**

- **Soft warm shades**
  Peach, apricot, terracotta. Warmth without shouting.
- **Evening and sleep**
  Gentle shades and warm light.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. **Orange warms her up and gets her moving.** The tradition advises warm and lively colours, for instance orange, yellow and red.

- **Add orange**
  A jumper, scarf, cushion, citrus fruit on the table.
- **Add movement**
  A walk, dancing, a brisker pace.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, the Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have two layers. A personal one (what we have experienced with the colour) and one shared by all people (images that repeat across ages and cultures).

In lectures at ETH in Zurich he linked colours with the functions of the psyche. Red with feeling, blue with thinking, green with the senses and yellow with intuition. **Jung did not describe orange as a separate function.** What I write next is my own reflection in the same spirit, not a statement by Jung.

How it relates to the colour orange. Orange is a blend of red and yellow, that is, of feeling and intuition. **It could be the colour of the moment when feeling and idea meet and the wish to act arises.** For Jung it was important that opposites do not have to exclude each other.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. Orange is not a separate element in the classical list of the five elements. According to many authors it belongs to the element of **earth** (together with yellow, brown and beige), and some link it also with **fire**. **Sources differ.**

In the map of the house called the bagua, the centre, the northeast and the southwest belong to earth. The southwest is linked with relationships and partnership. In a home orange is therefore often the colour of **warmth**, **nourishment** and **sociability**.

Orange is like turmeric

A little colours and warms a whole dish, a handful turns it into an experience that you then have on your fingers and on the tablecloth.

In feng shui orange therefore often works best as an **accent**. A cushion, lamp, ceramics, a painting or a detail on a textile adds warmth to a space. An orange wall, carpet and curtains all at once can already feel like a room that keeps inviting you to a party.

Simple tips

- **Want more warmth?**
  Add one orange piece where you will see it every day.
- **Want more calm?**
  Choose peach, apricot or terracotta and leave the rich one just for a detail.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add wood, linen, cream, blue or more free space.
- **Want more playfulness?**
  Take an orange crayon or a notebook and plan nothing with it.

And above all. Before you repaint a whole room, try **a throw**, **a fabric** or a larger colour **sample**. Your feeling is more important than the rules.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

What people say and what holds true

MYTH Orange is garish and does not belong in a home.

TRUTH A rich neon really does shout. But apricot, peach and terracotta are soft and warming. Start with a cushion or ceramics.

MYTH Orange adds energy.

TRUTH For some people yes, especially in the morning and among people. A rich orange in the bedroom in the evening may rather stir you up. Notice when it does you good.

MYTH The more orange, the more cheerful.

TRUTH Orange is like turmeric. A little warms, a handful overpowers everything else.

What orange works well with

- **Cream and linen**
  A softer whole in which orange does not have to shout.
- **Wood and clay**
  A more earthy, lived-in impression.
- **Blue**
  A striking warm and cool contrast; try which one will be the main one.
- **Green**
  It can recall a garden, leaves and fruit. Watch the richness of both colours.
- **Black**
  A strong contrast. If you do not want an impression of Halloween or sports kit, try only a little of it.
- **Grey and white**
  A cleaner, calmer impression. Orange easily stands out against them.

When you say colours “clash energetically”, you can start concretely. Are both too rich? Are there too many of them? Is their proportion not right for me? Change one thing and try spending some time in the room. Not just looking at it from the corridor.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Elements

In feng shui the elements are related to one another.

- **Fire creates earth**
  Terracotta, clay and brown tones calm and ground orange.
- **Wood feeds fire**
  A plant and an orange picture can feel alive and growing.
- **Water dampens fire**
  Symbolically blue and very dark blue belong here, the opposite of orange.
- **Earth supports metal**
  White, grey and metal add restraint to orange.

Take it as a **traditional image** of the relationships between elements, **not as a ban** on combining two colours in one room. Feng shui has several schools and the recommendations differ.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

Feng shui room by room

What works – what to watch for – a simple tip.

Living room

What works. Orange accessories. **Cushions**, **lamps**, **blankets**. A social place needs warmth. If the living room is grey and nobody much wants to sit in it, try an apricot or terracotta throw, a picture or a cushion next to wood and a light fabric.

What to watch for. If you have a striking sofa, a patterned carpet and several coloured decorations, further orange can make the impression **too dense**. The sofa does not have to compete with the television for the lead role.

A simple tip. Wool, linen and ceramics in apricot or terracotta **warm without shouting**. Glossy rich surfaces make noise in a room. Where in the room is it good to look from and where is it good to sit?

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Terracotta, apricot, warm wood. **Matt ceramics**, wood and a linen tablecloth in orange invite you to the table.

What to watch for. In a small hot kitchen with a glossy red worktop I would not add a large rich orange area. If a room already feels fiery, it may be more pleasant with **a light, matt and more restrained companion**.

A simple tip. Orange can accompany hospitality and gathering. The point is not to guarantee a bigger appetite, but to create a place where you want to **sit down**. A glossy orange worktop sounds louder than a mug on a shelf.

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author's written permission is not allowed.

Bedroom

What works. Orange in a small dose and in soft shades. Cotton and linen in peach or apricot are soft to look at and to touch.

What to watch for. First try a radiant orange across a whole room in a larger sample, also in the evening. If its look keeps you busy, reduce the area or move it **out of view from the bed**. A rich shine is less suited to falling asleep.

Peach is sometimes said to bring tenderness and a little romantic restlessness. In some interpretations of feng shui there is a link with “peach blossom luck”, that is, the theme of attraction and love life. Take it as a symbolic interpretation, not a prediction. A peach throw has no dating profile of its own. A more interesting question. What form of closeness do I want to live in my bedroom? Tenderness, playfulness, sensuality, or right now mainly calm and privacy?

A simple tip. A colour alone will not arrange sleep or passion. But it can belong to an environment in which you feel good. What do you see just before falling asleep and how does it feel to look at it?

Children's room

What works. Playful accents yes. Orange can be nice in a play corner, on a storage box or in a picture. Children like to touch colour too.

What to watch for. Whole walls, a bed, curtains and a carpet all in rich orange may suddenly be too stimulating. A child may have a livelier environment around play and a calmer view around the bed.

A simple tip. Orange storage boxes, a small rug or a cushion are playful and can be moved. When a room feels overcrowded, first try removing patterns and striking surfaces. Also take an interest in what is pleasant for the particular child.

Study and studio

What works. Soft orange for creativity. One orange picture or area by a place for ideas can be a pleasant lift.

What to watch for. A rich one can disturb concentration. When every object leads you away from work, leave orange out of the main view.

A simple tip. One orange thing on wood or paper adds a spark. Orange can be a great companion. I would rather not entrust it with the role of leading all your tasks in progress. From where is it pleasant to see into the room?

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.

Hallway and bathroom

What works. In the hall a smaller orange picture or a terracotta bench. In the bathroom an apricot towel or ceramics in a warm shade.

What to watch for. A narrow dark corridor can bear less rich orange than a light open space.

A simple tip. Ask yourself. Does the space **welcome me**, or does it shout at me right on arrival?

Ask yourself

“Why do I want orange at home? What is it meant to bring me. Warmth, playfulness, appetite?”

© 2026 MatyRoss · The Art of Wholeness. All rights reserved. Copying, distribution or any other use of the content without the author’s written permission is not allowed.